Q+A

MR. INDIA SHINES ON

Actor **Anil Kapoor** on his new series *The Night Manager* and his four decades in the film industry

Q. What's your process to build a character?
It's a lonely process. The character stays in your mind. You read, watch, think about them. Then come the dialogues and scenes. Read them once, fifty times, a hundred times... Then, upon reaching the set in the whole atmosphere, the confidence grows. In the end, the character shines on the editing table.

Q. Are you one of those actors who are prepared to risk hurting themselves on set?
To an extent. *Humlaa* (1992) had an action sequence. I had to fall from a height, as if the character didn't want to live... Cardboard boxes were kept below, but they weren't in order. I injured my leg and had to stay in bed for three months. Such things are common.

Q. Any scenes in your career that were born out of improvisation?
In *The Night Manager*, many scenes have been done through improvisation. The director or the first AD [Assistant Director] would come and explain the situation. Then, the actors would discuss it and the scene was built. This is the future on OTT now: people want to see performances where the actor shouldn't look like he or she is doing anything—it should look very real.

Q. K. Viswanath, who directed you in *Eeshwar* (1989), passed away recently. How do you remember him?
He brought out things in me that looked good on screen. His speciality was that if there was any fakeness in a shot, he'd catch it. Bapu was the kind of director who explained acting in such simple terms that I was always surprised when I grasped what he meant.

Q. Actors also contribute to the script. Like Govinda. The entire dialogue threatening Satish Kaushik in *Deewana Mastana* (1997) was probably written by him. Have you shared your inputs as well?
(Laughing) In that film, I used to tell Govinda to give me some of the punchlines he was writing for himself. I added value to a scene in *Slumdog Millionaire* (2008) with Danny Boyle. Some directors give such space. Vidhu Vinod Chopra is also one of them.

with Gajendra Singh Bhati



MILIND SHELTE